live visuals playing at Times Square in New York and Burj Khalifa in Dubai. A Gujarat-based event management firm has won the tender. It is expected to cost Rs 150 crore, a figure that met with objections initially owing to Bengal's straitened finances but was finally deemed a reasonable expense to bear for the showcasing of *sanatana*.

That last bit provides a new point of emphasis for the Suvendu dispensation, even if it's proceeding along a heuristic, trial-and-error



Takeaways

- **Eden Gardens to host PM Modi for grand show on Mahalaya, Oct. 10**
- **CM keen to be seen as "agent of change"; pujas shift patronage**
- **VHP veto on freestyle idols, but backtracks on non-veg food**

path. One experimental foray was against the secular, if traditional, synonym for Durga Puja—'Sharadotsav', festival of the autumnal Sharad *ritu*. On September 10, he lanced the Left's recourse to that pretext while putting up bookstalls at pandals."You consider this festival merely cultural? If these communists don't write 'Durga Puja' on their stalls, don't allot any to them." Days later, his tone softened. All he wanted, he said, was for "puja according to the scriptures" not to be forgotten amid the pageantry.

The cultural politics of the Sangh Parivar outed itself on two other fronts. The Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) cast a scrutinous eye on flamboyant pandal themes, carried over to Durga idols. Depictions of the goddess not aligned with traditions won't be tolerated, it said. That was less contentious, even if it shrinks Bengal's unique iconographic aesthetic: rooted in native art traditions, it also makes space for modern interpretations.

THE NON-VEG COUNTER

The second one didn't swim too far: the VHP criticised the sale of non-vegetarian food near pandals and warned it could "intervene" against transgressions, unsettling organisers. At an event in Howrah, in the CM's presence, the young televangelist Dhirendra Shastri aka 'Bageshwar baba' castigated Bengalis for consuming non-veg during Puja. A backlash forced both regime and VHP to backtrack and clarify that there was no question of interfering with Bengal's culinary traditions. Liquor shops will be shut on Ashtami, though. In what the more sedate Bengali will accept as reform, DJs will be banned in pandals and during idol immersions.

At a dross level, 'politics' means capture of puja committees: netas patronising marquee pujas, securing plum sponsorships. In 2026, the stated intent of "dissociating Durga Puja from politicians" aside, that clientilistic pact is only changing its boss. The baton change is at times forced, as at South Kolkata's Haridevpur, where organisers sought police protection after alleged BJP-linked vandalism and threats. The CM will be seen at Chetla Agrani Club pujo, led by TMC renegade Firhad Hakim. This much is par for the course in Bengal. ■

▶ BIHAR

A Question Wrapped in a Quota

Two Dalit parties, the face of different segments, go at each other—the debate prises open an old dilemma

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

ITS RHETORICAL SHARPNESS WAS THE MOST striking feature of Bihar minister Santosh Suman's foray in social media on September 13. "Who is spreading the lie that classifying Scheduled Castes will end reservation?" he wrote. "Those who claim to be the messiah of Dalits should answer first." Suman, son of former chief minister Jitan Ram Manjhi, was not shooting arrows into a void. This was a rebuttal to Union minister Chirag Paswan, whose position on the subject is equally emphatic: since reservations came about in response to social discrimination, there can be neither a creamy layer nor 'reservation within reservation'.





FAULT LINE REVIVED Union minister Chirag Paswan and Santosh Suman, son of former CM Jitan Ram Manjhi